Sports Psychology

By Janet O'Neill

I never had many conversations with my father until I was 7, when he taught me the art of the curve. Most adults don't know how to throw a curve ball, but my father had me sinking that ball several inches in a matter of months. Yes, baseball, because dad said softball was the weaker sport and I' m not weak! Soon, we were watching football on Sunday afternoons and I was caddying for him at local golf tournaments. And soon, I'd found a best friend.

INTRODUCTION

In the past, fathers could stare down at the boy in the bassinet and dream of fishing trips and games of catch. Dreams for little girls were very different . . . softer. Today, however, when it comes to raising, happy and confident young women, "parent" is an equal opportunity position. Fathers and daughters have much to talk about, worlds to share. Learning to hit a curve ball or make the smart career move--once largely the arena of fathers and sons--is now fully and joyfully open to fathers and daughters. Thank Title IX for giving girls the opportunity to not only compete in sports, but to aspire to compete at the highest level. Thank equal opportunity for giving young women the ability to enter the professions and climb up organizations in numbers equal to men. Daddy's Little Girl has taken on new meaning . . . Sports Psychology by Janet O'Neill.

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Let's get one thing straight: it wasn't that dad was sports obsessed. It wasn't that I felt pushed into playing. We'd merely found a way to communicate. A way to cross the barriers between adult and child, man and girl. Sport was a culture. A language.

My moments with my father can be told as a series of sports stories. A veritable highlight reel, as my dad would say. Ready for some sports stories? Kickoff occurs now.

July, 1981. My first day in softball. We'd given up the baseball dream at this point. See, I could make the ball sink, but I couldn't catch or hit-two vital skills to life as a ball player. So I'm playing softball, playing deep right/center field. See, we had 14 players and we were just kids, so the league said everyone gets to play the field. I'm behind the outfielders because, well, I my

athleticism wasn't exactly working out. I'd spend my time stepping on ant hills and looking into the sun. The chances of a 9 year-old girl popping one out 250 feet to where I was wasn't too likely. Still, dad's on the bleachers yelling "Hit one out there to my Adrian!! She'll show you how it's done!!" Unless Mike Schmidt had joined girls youth softball, I wasn't going to show anyone how it was done. "Hit it to Adrian!" Yeah, dad, I thought as I stepped on an ant pile. Rebuild.

November, 1983. Dad takes me to a football game at his alma-mater. We pack a thermos full of hot chocolate and bear the cold of University of Minnesota football. Beforehand, he takes me to see where he lived, as well as the fireplace at the union where he first met mom, as well as the restaurant he first took her out to. I catch him sneaking a beer out of the trunk and I call him on it. Did you bring enough for everyone? After the game, Dad says just two words: "Good day." I turn the radio to the post-game show as we drive home.

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March, 1985. Dad and I watch the Georgetown/Villanova basketball game. Georgetown was favored by a bazillion points. Villanova won. "That could be you," dad says, "That could be you."

May, 1986. My first soccer league game. I still ran, well, I ran not even like a girl, so they put me in as goalie. I love the way my abilities always dictated my position! But something weird happened that day. No one scored. That's right. No one. I didn't give up a goal. Neither did the other goalie, but still. A scoreless tie. Greatest moment of my life. Dad went home to make phone calls. A phenom was on his hands! But what if I had to play soccer again?

May, 1986-three days later. My next game. People are kicking the ball hard this game. At me! I blocked it with my hands, my chest, my butt, my head. I dove around. No one scored. Coming home from the game, we both looked at my muddied uniform and didn't say a word. The dirt said it all. Dad didn't make phone calls that night. People called him.

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June, 1988. By this point, I'd grown another 5 inches. I was Amazon woman! And I wasn't quite as uncoordinated as I used to be. Not so many soccer ball imprints on my face. Colleges started calling. Dad started giving me advice:

1.) Never listen to anything a college says. If they say you're good, it just is part of a script read over the phone.

2.) Never doubt yourself If a college says you aren't good, they just haven't watched you play enough.

3.) Sports equates to college. College equates to degrees. Degrees equate to jobs. Jobs equate to success. Thus, sports can equal success, but you've got to know your math.

4.) Never count on sports. Count on him. Dad. Sports will come and go. You may find yourself stepping on anthills a year from now, so count on people. And yourself

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August, 1989. Dad and I embark on our tours of college campuses. Everywhere from Virginia to UCLA. Dad buys a video camera to capture the moments. The guy who sold it said "just press play." Unfortunately, it took a little more than" just press play." First time I'd ever heard my dad swear. The "S" word. A bonding moment.

On the way, we bought a regular camera. As we passed each state line, we stopped at the border, set the timer, and took pictures of the two of us next to the state welcome signs.

September, 1989. I'm playing against Westview, our rival, when all of a sudden I see players running up into the stands. I focus on the game. It's tied 1-1. Out of the corner of my eye, I see my coach bolt for the bleachers. As I look, I see they are headed for row 5, where dad always sits.

The next thing I know, I'm running for him. I'm still not a good runner, but today I am. I'm next to him and he's not saying anything. Not "help". Not "don't

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worry, Adrian". Not even, "give me a second". He's just lying there.

Fifteen minutes pass. Fifteen minutes I still can't recall. The next thing I remember, I'm at the hospital. They tell me I can't see him so I dash for the chapel. I get down on my knees and pray. Pray for answers, pray for my eyes to open and I'll be back in front of the goal and dad is saying, "Good block, kid!"

I pray for him to live. I get my wish. My father has suffered a massive stroke. He cannot speak. No one knows how bad it actually is. I visit him and he shows no recognition. No smile.

November, 1989. I realize that we never got the pictures developed from our college trip last summer. I take the pictures to a local department store and three days later I return for them. I look through the picture bin, but they're not there. Maybe they couldn't read the handwriting. Check under other letters. A through Z, they're not there.

I ask the clerk, "Excuse me, but are pictures running late today?" She informs me that everything is

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on time. "Then where are my pictures?" He says, Oh, you're Adrian Clark, aren't you? I'm sorry, but your pictures didn't come out. Overexposed. May have been our fault. The next set of developing is on us.

It takes me 10 seconds to register what was just said. The last pictures I will ever have of my father with his arm around me, of his smile, of his glow and support.. .are gone. Gone. But hey, I should be happy because I get a free set of developing next time.

And, see, I want that film. I've gotta have that film. I've been counting on it. It's all have left of the father I know. And I wasn't the one who messed it up - they did. So fix my damn pictures and give them back. No "please". No "excuse me, fix my pictures". Just get me my pictures. The clerk doesn't know what has hit her and calls for the manager. I say, "They screwed up my pictures. Give me back my pictures!" The manager calls my mom and she comes to get me. Now, I know what you're thinking. That last story doesn't have anything to do with Sports. Not all of these moments are sports-related. Don't you get it by now? Nothing has to do with

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sports. Sports represent a means to an end. Sports was communication for my dad and myself That's it. Nothing is ever what it seems.

Let's say you join a country club. To play golf. It's all about sports, but it's not. It's about meeting friends, escaping from home. Let's say you jog daily. It's about sports, but it's not. Really you love the nature or you love skipping your homework to run, or your father has a massive stroke when he's 49 years old and he should have run more.

See, sports are just a cover. Communicating messages only certain people comprehend. Masking life so we can take it all in without saying so.

October, 1993. My team is in the NCAA playoffs for the first time. I'm in goal for our first televised game. I left for the game after making mom leave it on for dad to watch. She says he showed no expression during the game. We won, 2-0. Trust me, he showed expression. It may not have been about the game, but it was there. See, it's all about sports, but it's not.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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